



IN CONTEXT

Dire forecasts

In 1474, German mathematician and astronomer Johannes Müller published *Ephemerides*, tables of the position of celestial bodies. After his death, it was alleged that a verse prophecy found among his papers foretold calamities for the year 1588. Astrologers linked Müller's predictions with their own fears about a rare conjunction of Saturn and Jupiter that took place in 1583. Despite widespread alarm and speculation, Müller's predicted disasters failed to occur.



Ephemerides is a table of moon phases by Johannes Müller, who was better known as Regiomontanus (King's Mountain).

predictions dwelling on the date of the end of the world. They flourished at times of social turmoil, when political tirades could be disguised as astrological predictions. In England, William Lilly's *Merlini Anglicus Ephemeris* found wide circulation during the English Civil War (his first almanac came out mid-war in 1645). Lilly became so famous that he was arrested in 1666 after the Great Fire of London, as he had predicted a conflagration and was suspected of having caused it.

Nostradamus

Even more famous was the French physician and astrologer Michel de Nostredame, or Nostradamus. He began producing an annual almanac in 1550, and his reputation as a prophet soared after he apparently predicted the death of the king, Henri II, in a jousting accident in 1559. His predictions were collated in *The Prophecies*, written in obscure poetic quatrains that mask their meaning. These verses are said by some to have foretold events from the French Revolution at the end of the 18th century to the 9/11 attacks against the US in 2001.

In the 17th century, purely scientific almanacs, with ever more precise astronomical tables, appealed to equally scientific-minded buyers while, at the other end of the market, popular and folk almanacs, such as *Old Moore's Almanac*, continued. First published in 1764, this almanac is still published yearly in the 21st century.

▼ Chronicle of the future

The predictions that come after this title page of Nostradamus's *The Prophecies* still find followers in the present century.

